adjudged to have cleanly caught a top-edged pull off Pat Cummins. Broady made 56 from 63 balls and helped me to be 244 not out at the end of a day in which I passed Mahela Jayawardene, Shivnarine Chanderpaul and Brian Lara in the all-time run list.

Jimmy was out for 0 from the first ball he faced the following morning, and I carried my bat for the first time in Test cricket. Only two of my thirty-three Test centuries have been more substantial, 263 against Pakistan in Abu Dhabi in 2015, and 294 against India at Edgbaston in 2011. Funnily enough, the principle of that sort of achievement resonates across sports.

The Saracens guys were fascinated by the underpinning philosophy of daddy hundreds when the Essex squad visited them, to share ideas and experiences. Their team meeting was based on the imposition and continuation of dominance, since they were in the process of becoming England's best rugby team. Specifically, they wanted to pick my brains about the Ashes tour of 2010–11, when I scored a record 766 runs at an average of 127.66.

Firstly, they had to understand its context. The unbeaten 235 in Brisbane, in the first Test, was my first double hundred. It had taken me nearly five years, and a lot of growing up, to learn how to make it. The highest score in my previous thirteen Test centuries had been 173, against Bangladesh in Chittagong the previous March.

Opening the batting is a bit like walking in the Himalayas. The air is thin and you're climbing constantly. It is easy to make mistakes through inexperience. When I first started playing, scoring a hundred was such a big thing. Once you reached three figures, you felt the weight of the achievement lift, and switched off a little. It was almost 'job done'. It was a goal to be ticked off, rather like reaching the requisite level in a fitness test.

It took longer to identify the importance of batting for longer periods. I had to learn to deal with the troublesome Gimp on my shoulder, whose negativity was making me expend too much mental energy. With him in his cage, I had more resources to devote to my batting. I began to realize that a big hundred, 160 or 170, provided greater insurance against the bad days, when I would be out cheaply to the new ball.

The biggest opening partnership I had was 373, with Nick Browne against Middlesex at Chelmsford in June 2017. It fell just short of the overall Essex record of 403, set by Goochy and Paul Prichard for the second wicket in 1990. That was all my fault; Ollie Rayner had me caught